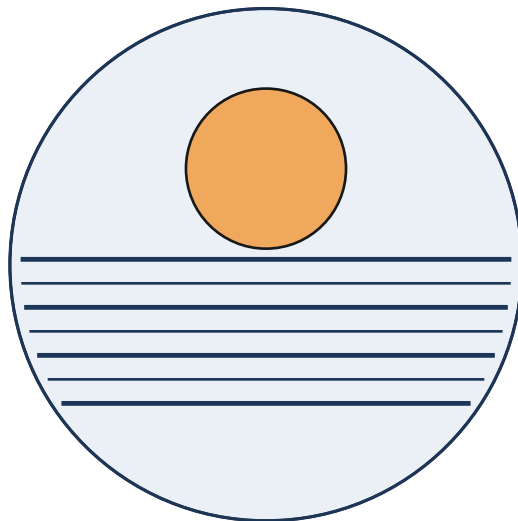


Kestrel Island

Field Station Review

A record of the thirty-first season, with the counts, the weather, the building work, and the forms the warden would rather you filled in before you arrive than after.

Published by the Kestrel Island Trust



Thirty-first season

Not a real place

What is in here

This review is written once a year, in the fortnight after the last boat of the season leaves and before the weather closes the crossing for the winter. It is meant to be read by three kinds of people: the members of the trust, who pay for the roof; the visiting ringers and surveyors, who want to know what happened while they were away; and whoever inherits the wardenship, who will find that every number in it has a story behind it.

The sections

1. **Foreword.** Why the season was shorter than usual, and what that cost.
2. **The season in brief.** Landings, weather, and the state of the buildings.
3. **Four plates.** A photograph of the north shore, the ringing totals as a chart, a drawing of the tide gauge, and a study of the paint we now use on the boat house.
4. **The year end to end.** One wide sheet with every week on it.
5. **A page that arrived turned.** Left as it came, on purpose.
6. **The visitor permit.** Two pages of form. Fill it in, do not print it.
7. **A page with remarks on it.** What a marked-up draft looks like.
8. **Colophon.** How this document was put together.

A note on the numbers

Bird counts are the warden's, taken at the same three points on the same walk, in the first two hours after sunrise. Weather is from the station's own gauge on the roof of the store, which is not a certified instrument and has never pretended to be. Where a figure is estimated it says so.

Foreword

The season opened eleven days late. The winter gales had taken the top two courses of stone off the landing wall, and until the wall was rebuilt there was nowhere on the island a loaded boat could come alongside without a swell under it. Nobody was hurt, no equipment was lost, and the wall is better now than it has been since the trust bought the place. But eleven days at the front of a season are not eleven days in the middle of one, and the two weeks we lost were the two weeks the first passage birds use the island.

What that means in practice is written into every table in this review, and it would be dishonest to leave the reader to discover it in the numbers. The spring totals are low because we were not there to count, not because the birds did not come.

A gap in a record is not a small number. It is no number at all, and a table that does not say which of the two it is holding has stopped being a record and become a decoration.

The rest of the season went well. The new gauge in the sound has run without a break since the eighth week. The bunkhouse took forty-one visitors across nineteen separate stays, which is the most since the trust started keeping count, and not one of them arrived without a permit, which is the first time that has ever been true.

We put that down to the form. It used to be a sheet of paper that had to be printed, filled in by hand, photographed on a kitchen table and sent back as four unreadable pictures. It is now two pages that can be filled in on the machine the visitor is already sitting at, signed there, and sent back as one file. The change cost the trust nothing and saved the warden about a day a month, which over a season is a fortnight of somebody's life given back.

What comes next

The roof of the store is the next thing. It is not leaking yet. It is the kind of roof that does not leak for years and then leaks everywhere in one night, and the trust has agreed to look at it in the spring rather than find out which kind of night it is going to be.

The season in brief

Nineteen stays, forty-one visitors, one hundred and sixty-two nights slept on the island. The boat crossed on eighty-eight days and was turned back by weather on twenty-two, which is close to the ten-year average and a good deal better than the two seasons before it. The generator ran for four hundred and six hours. The rain gauge on the store roof collected six hundred and eleven millimetres, of which nearly a fifth fell in the single week at the end of the eighth month that everybody who was here will remember.

Getting on and off

The landing wall was rebuilt in the first eleven days of the season by four people, two of whom had never laid a stone before and one of whom had laid nothing else for thirty years. The stone came from the old sheep fold above the beach, which the trust had been meaning to take down since it bought the island and which had been quietly falling down on its own in the meantime. Nothing was brought over from the mainland except lime, sand and the loan of a mixer.

The wall is now two courses higher than it was and set back a hand's breadth further from the water, which sounds like nothing and is the whole difference. A boat coming alongside at half tide in a westerly used to touch the old face before the fender did. It no longer does.

What the rebuild cost the season is set out plainly in the table below, and the reader should take the spring figures as incomplete rather than low.

Period	Boat days	Visitors	Nights
Early season	9	4	11
Spring	21	9	34
High summer	34	19	78
Late season	24	9	39

Weather

The station keeps three instruments: a rain gauge, a maximum and minimum thermometer in a screen behind the store, and an anemometer on the mast that has been repaired so often it should probably be described as a different anemometer. None of them is certified. All of them are read at the same hour every day by whoever is holding the log, and the value of that consistency is worth more to the record than the accuracy of any one reading.

The season was warmer than the ten-year mean by about half a degree and markedly wetter. The wet was not spread out. Four weeks of the season accounted for

more than half the rain, and the week in the eighth month accounted for a fifth of it on its own. The gauge overflowed once, on the Thursday, and the figure for that day is recorded as a minimum and marked as such in the log.

Wind was unremarkable until the last fortnight, when a run of northerlies kept the boat on the mainland for six days out of eight and gave the island its quietest week of the year. Two visitors who had planned three nights stayed nine. Both of them have asked to come back.

The buildings

The bunkhouse is sound. The window on the seaward side was reglazed in the fourth month after a stone came through it, which is the third time in six years, and the trust has agreed that the fourth time will be answered with a shutter rather than another pane.

The store is the problem, and it is the kind of problem that does not look like one. The roof is original, the felt is beyond its life, and the timbers underneath are still dry only because nothing has yet found a way through. Two people who know roofs have looked at it and given the same opinion in almost the same words: it will hold, and when it stops holding it will stop everywhere at once. The trust has put it first on the list for the spring.

The boat house was painted, which is why there is a plate about paint later in this review. The colour was chosen badly the first time, in a hurry, from a chart held up against a wall on a bright day, and the result was a shade that looked correct for about a fortnight and then looked like nothing on the island at all. It was done again properly, against the rock, in the rain, and the difference is the sort of thing that is impossible to argue about in words and obvious in a photograph.

The gauge in the sound

The tide gauge went in during the sixth week and has run without a break since. It is a simple thing, and simple on purpose: a stilling well, a float, a shaft, and a counter that writes a number to a card once a minute. There is no radio in it. Somebody walks out to it once a fortnight, swaps the card, and walks back. A drawing of how it works is included as one of the plates, because more people ask about it than about anything else on the island and a drawing answers the question faster than a paragraph does.

The reason it has no radio is not thrift. It is that the sound is a bad place for a mast, the nearest thing to put one on is a rock that goes under at spring tides, and a gauge that reports nothing for six hours twice a month is worse than a gauge that reports everything a fortnight late. The card has never failed. The card is not going to fail.

Ringling

Totals are in the second plate, month by month. The short version is that the spring is missing, the autumn is the best on record, and the difference between those two facts is entirely the eleven days at the start.

Four visitors held licences this year, which is one more than last year and the most the station has had at once. Two of them trained a third between them across three separate stays, which is a slow way to train somebody and the only way that works. The trust has agreed to keep paying the crossing for trainees, and the warden would like it noted that this is the cheapest good thing the trust does.

Money

The trust is solvent, which for a body of this size means it has enough put by to do one unplanned thing a year without asking anybody. This year the unplanned thing was the wall. Next year it is going to be the roof, and the roof is not going to leave room for anything else.

Membership stands at two hundred and thirty-one, up nine. Nobody has left. Six members have been members since the trust was founded, and the warden would like to thank all six of them by name, and has been told firmly that this is not what a review is for.

Plate I

First light on the north shore

The north shore faces the open water and takes the weather first. This is the view from the top of the path at the hour the counts begin, which is the only hour of the day when the light comes along the beach rather than down onto it, and the only hour when the whole run of the shore can be seen at once from a single place.



The north shore at the hour the counts begin, from the top of the path.
The near headland is the one that shelters the landing; the far one is across the sound.

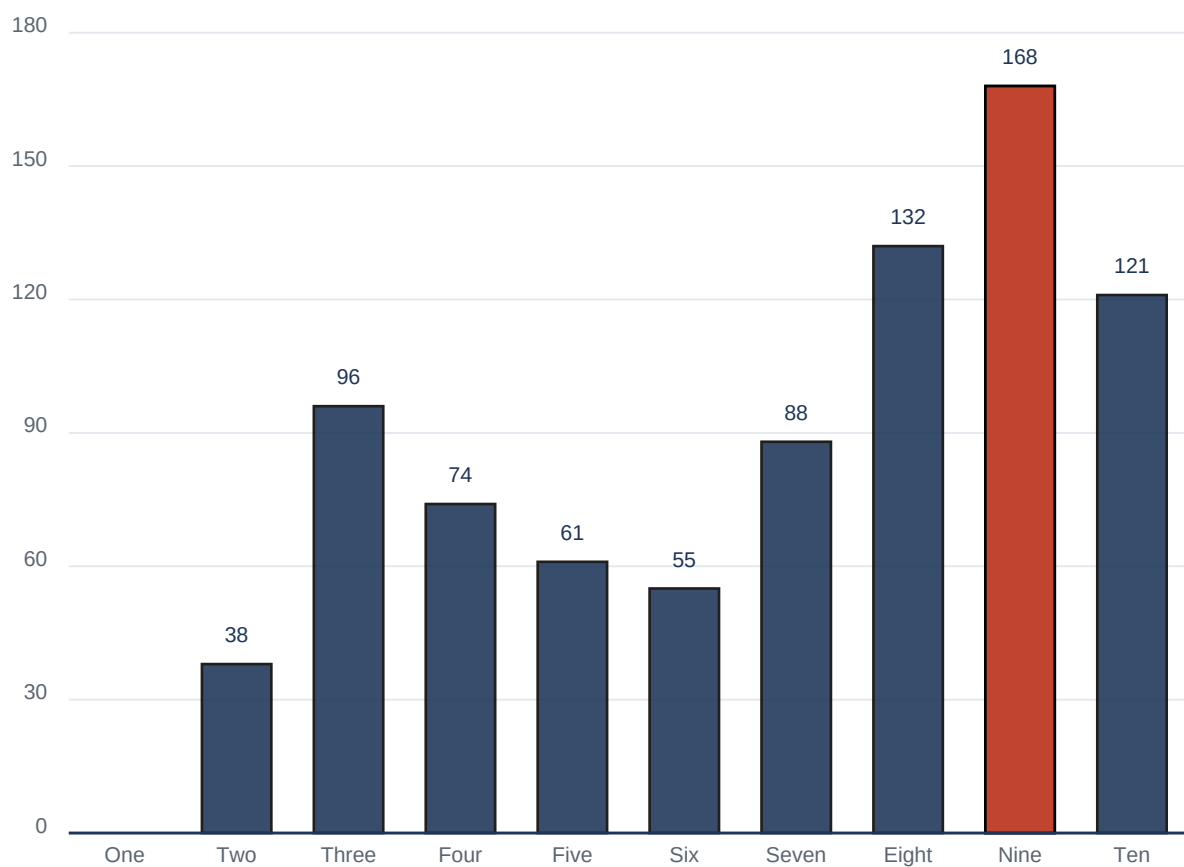
Plate II

Birds ringed, by month

The shape of this chart is the shape of the season. Nothing in the first month because nobody was on the island; a thin spring because the passage had largely gone through by the time the wall was finished; and then the best autumn the station has recorded, helped by a fortnight of northerlies that put birds on the ground and kept the boat on the mainland.

Birds ringed each month of the season

833 in all

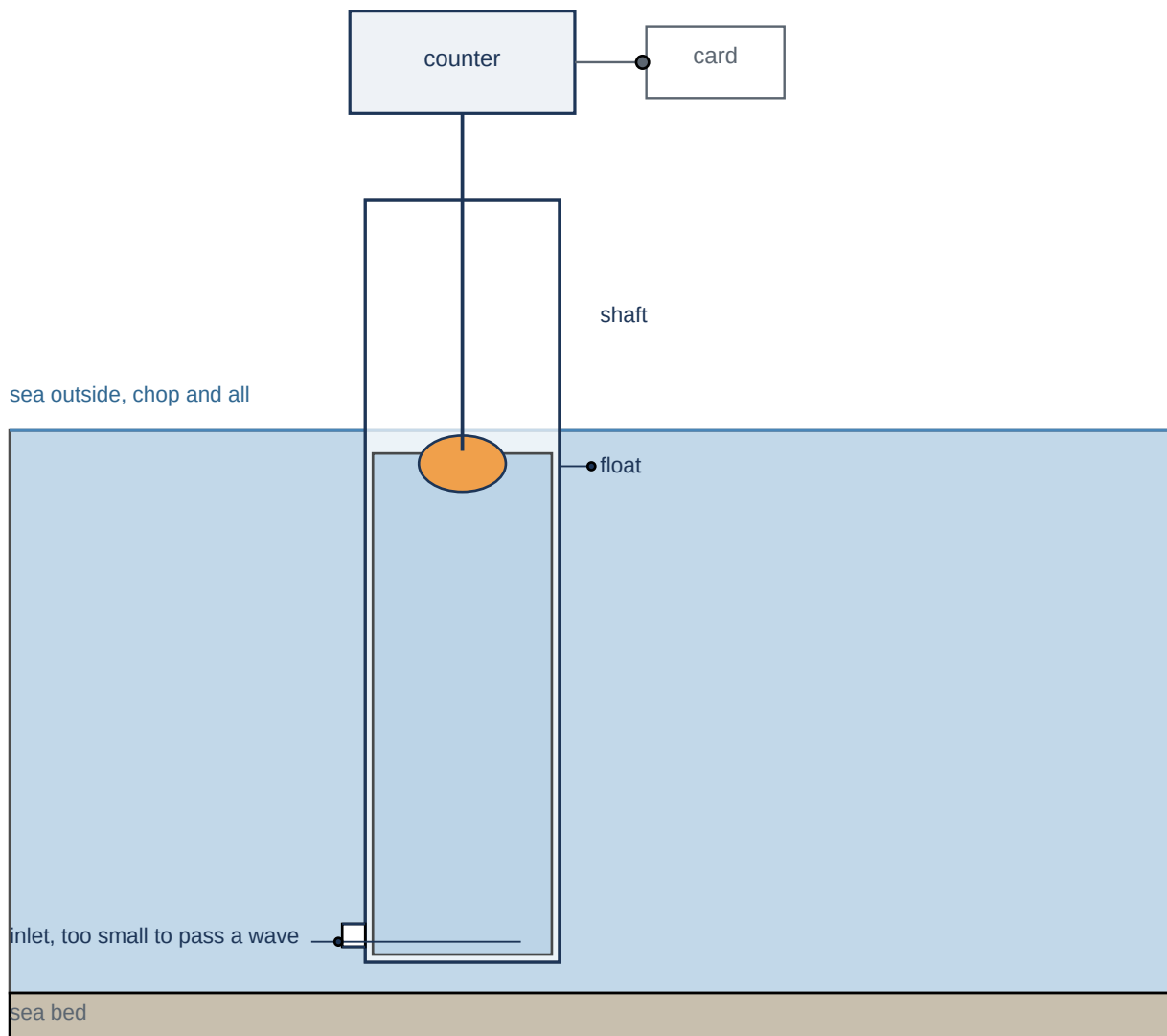


The first month is not a low bar. It is no bar, because there was nobody on the island to count.
The ninth month, in red, is the best the station has recorded.

Plate III

How the tide gauge works

Sea water enters the stilling well through a narrow inlet at the foot. The inlet is deliberately too small to pass a wave: the level inside the well follows the tide and ignores the chop, which is the whole trick. A float on the water carries a shaft; the shaft turns a counter; the counter writes one number to a card every minute. Nothing in the chain needs power except the counter, and the counter runs a year on two cells.

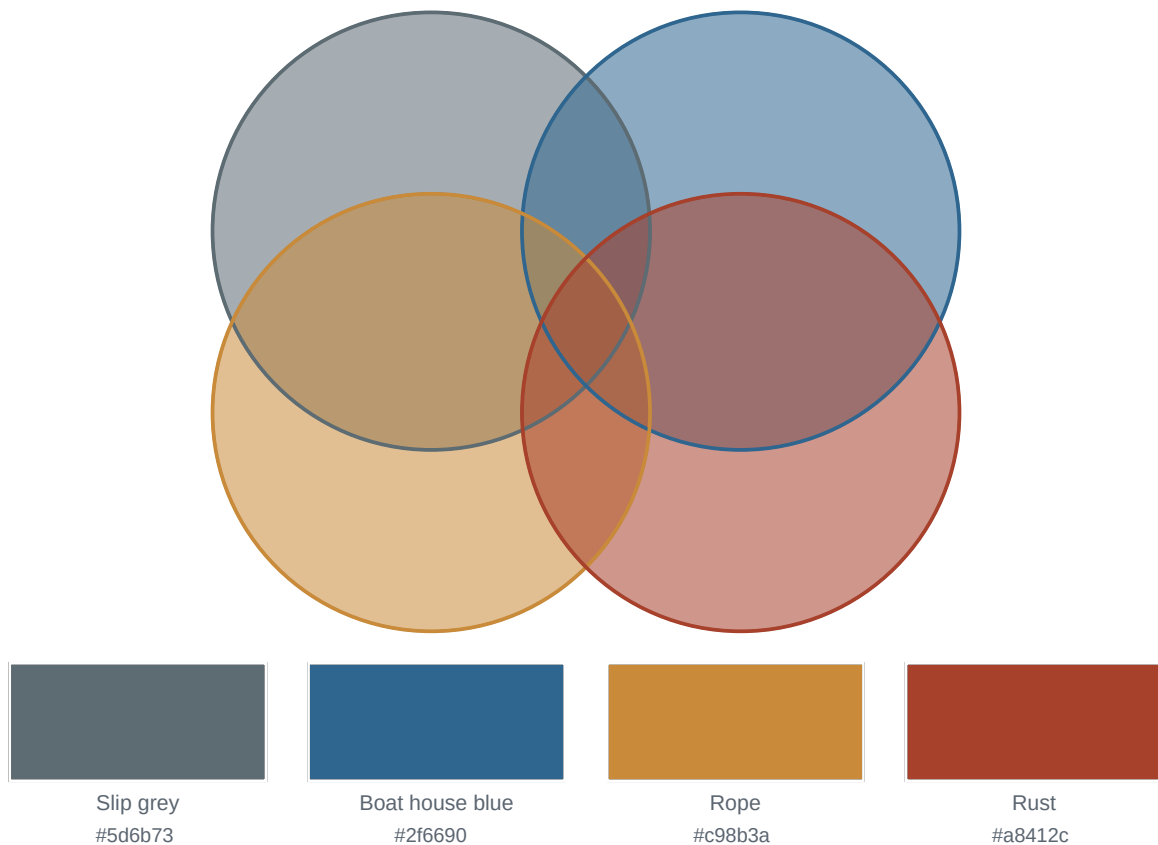


The stilling well in the sound. Nothing in the chain needs power except the counter, and the counter runs a year on two cells. The card is fetched on foot once a fortnight.

Plate IV

Colour, transparency and stroke

Four washes of the boat house paint, laid over one another as they would fall on a wall that has been painted twice and touched up three times. The rings are drawn at fifty-five parts in a hundred, so that what is underneath still counts. Everything on this page is drawn rather than photographed: a circle here is an instruction to the reader's machine, not a grid of dots, and it stays sharp at any size a printer or a screen cares to ask for.



Four washes at fifty-five parts in a hundred, and the same four laid flat underneath. The rings are stroked at full strength, which is why they survive being overlapped.

The year, end to end

A wide sheet, because the year is wider than it is tall. Each row is a month of the season and each column a thing worth counting. The sheet is set on paper turned the long way round, which is a different matter from a page that has been turned after the fact; the next page in this review is one of those, and the two are worth comparing.

Month	Boat days	Visitors	Nights	Ringed	Rain mm	Notes
One	2	0	0	0	74	Landing wall down, no landings
Two	7	4	11	38	52	Wall rebuilt, season opened
Three	11	5	18	96	41	First full counts
Four	10	4	16	74	63	Bunkhouse window reglazed
Five	12	6	25	61	38	Gauge installed in the sound
Six	11	7	29	55	29	Quietest month for weather
Seven	11	6	24	88	47	Boat house repainted
Eight	8	4	17	132	141	The wet week
Nine	9	3	14	168	66	Best fortnight on record
Ten	7	2	8	121	60	Northerlies, boat held ashore

Ten months, eighty-eight boat days, forty-one visitors, one hundred and sixty-two nights, eight hundred and thirty-three birds ringed, and six hundred and eleven millimetres of rain. The first row is the one to look at twice: two boat days and nothing else, because there was nowhere to land.

A page that arrived turned

This page is a quarter turn out and has been left that way on purpose.

It came in as part of a scanned bundle from the boatyard, upright on the glass but with the page instruction saying otherwise, which is what a great many scanners do and what a great many documents therefore carry for ever. Nothing is wrong with the words on it. The only thing wrong is which way up the page says it should be shown.

Turning it back is one button, and it is worth knowing that the button does not redraw anything. The page instruction changes and the words underneath stay exactly the bytes they were. That distinction matters most for a scan: a page that has been re-rendered to straighten it has lost something, and a page whose instruction has been corrected has lost nothing at all.

The boatyard's note, as received

Slip repaired to the waterline. Two of the rollers were seized and have been replaced; the third was sound and was left. The winch cable has about a season left in it and should be renewed before the spring, not after. Charge as agreed, less the roller that was not needed.

The yard would like it noted that the tide gauge float was collected on the same trip and is in their store awaiting the spring crossing.

Visitor permit

Fill this in on the machine you are already sitting at and send it back as one file. Do not print it, sign it and photograph it: the warden has spent enough of his life turning four pictures of a kitchen table back into a form. Two of the answers are not optional, and the program you are reading this in marks those with a red rule.

The visitor

Name in full

Marren Holt

Electronic address

Society or institution

Fern Bay Ringing Group

Telephone, if you have one

Postal address

17 Quay Road, Fern Bay

The stay

Arriving on

2026-05-14

Nights

6

Purpose of the visit

Ringing

Where you will sleep

- ☒ Bunkhouse
☐ The cabin
☐ Own tent

Meals

- ☒ No meat
☐ No wheat

Skills you can offer

Boat handling
First aid
Ringing licence
Weather logging
Stonework
Diving

Two answers are not optional: the name in full and the electronic address. Everything else can wait.

Declaration

Four undertakings, a box to tick, and somewhere to sign. The panel takes a signature drawn or captured on the machine, and the warden will take a typed name from anybody whose machine cannot manage that.

1. I will keep to the marked paths above the tide line between the fifteenth week and the twenty-second, which is when the ground is nesting.
2. I will carry my own rubbish off the island, including the rubbish I find, which is a request rather than an undertaking and is usually agreed to.
3. I understand that the crossing is weather dependent, that the boat is not a ferry, and that a booked departure is a hope rather than a promise.
4. I have read the fire notice in the bunkhouse, or I will read it within an hour of arriving, which is the same thing said honestly.

Agreement

☐ I have read the four undertakings above and agree to them

In your own words

Anything the warden ought to know

Signing

Sign here

Date of signing

Start again

Send the permit

Sending the form does not book the crossing. The warden writes back, and the boat is the boatman's to give.

A page with remarks on it

This is the draft of the paragraph about the store roof, as it came back from the second reader, and it has been left in the review with the marks still on it so that anybody who has not seen a marked-up page can see what one looks like. There are four kinds of mark here and each is a different thing.

A highlight is a wash of colour over words that are already there. It says look at this, and it says nothing else. It does not change a letter of what is underneath, and taking it off again leaves the page exactly as it was.

A note is a marker with a remark folded up inside it. The marker is small on purpose. The remark can be as long as the reader likes, and it stays out of the way of the words until somebody opens it.

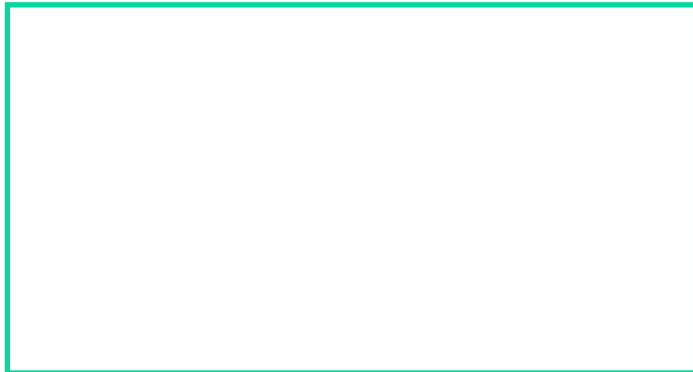
A drawn line is a hand. Somebody has circled a figure or struck through a line, and the line is theirs, in their own wobble, at whatever thickness they were pressing. It carries information that a neat box does not.

A box is a boundary. It says this much, from here to here, and it is what to reach for when the thing being marked is not a run of words but an area: a picture, a table, an empty space where something ought to be.

The paragraph as it stood

The store roof is original. The felt is at the end of its life and the timbers below it are dry only because nothing has yet found a way through them. Two people who know roofs have looked at it and said the same thing: it will hold, and when it stops holding it will stop everywhere at once. The trust has agreed to look at it in the spring. The estimate of four hundred and forty is the yard's, given over the telephone, and should be treated as a number somebody said rather than a number anybody has stood behind.

Marks live beside the page rather than in it. Every one of them can be taken off and the paper underneath is untouched, which is the reason a marked-up draft is safe to send to somebody who is going to typeset it.



Colophon

This document was set from plain text by the same program that reads it. No page in it was drawn by hand and no page was pasted in from anywhere else.

The body is Times at ten and a half points on a fourteen point line, set justified, with the spaces between words stretched rather than the letters. Headings are Helvetica. Both are among the fourteen fonts every reader is required to know, so nothing had to be embedded and the file stays small enough to send.

The chart, the diagram and the colour study are vector drawings: rectangles, ellipses and lines with fills, strokes and transparency, placed by coordinates measured in points from the bottom left of the page. The photograph is the one thing on any page made of dots.

The form is a real form. The fields were built from a description rather than drawn, which is how the same layout can be produced again after somebody moves a label. Two of the fields will not let the form be sent while they are empty.

The marks on the page of remarks are comments in the proper sense: they sit beside the page, not in it, and removing them leaves the words underneath exactly as they were.

The table of contents was written last, from the sections that turned out to exist rather than the ones that were planned.

Rebuilding this

The whole document is produced by one script in the repository. If a heading moves, or the paint changes colour, or somebody finds a better word for the tide gauge, the script is edited and run again and the file comes out the same way every time. That is the point of it. A showcase nobody can rebuild stops being true about six weeks after it is made.

Not real

Kestrel Island does not exist. Neither does the trust, the warden, the boatyard, the tide gauge or any of the birds. Every number in this review was invented to be the kind of number that would be there.